

AIRCRAFT THAT CRASHED

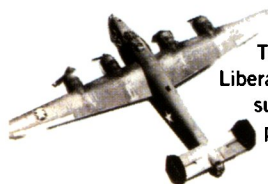


Douglas C-47 Skytrain/Dakota Allied workhorse during the war could carry 2.7 tonne of cargo or 28 troops to 2,400 km; one of the most famous military aircraft ever built.

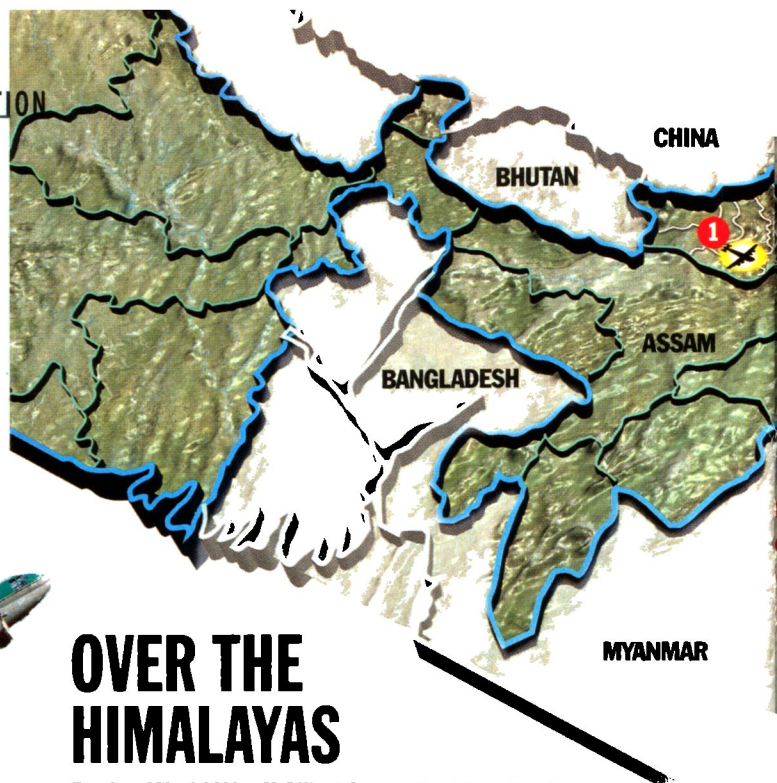


Consolidated B-24 Liberator Iconic heavy bomber of WWII. Phenomenal range of nearly 6,000 km and an internal bomb load of 3 tonne.

Curtiss-Wright C-46 Commando Designed as a commercial airliner but converted into military transport during the war. Had a range of 4,750 km and could carry 6 tonne of cargo.



C-87 Liberator Express Transport variant of Liberator bomber meant to surpass the Dakota's performance.



OVER THE HIMALAYAS

During World War II Allied forces lost hundreds of aircraft over China, Burma and India. Only seven crash sites in India have been identified.

Swanson, co-pilot flying officer Sheldon L. Chambers, navigator 1st Lt. Irwin 'Zipper' Zaetz, bombardier 1st Lt. Robert E. Oxford, engineer Sgt. Charles D. Ginn, radio operator Sgt. Harry B. Queen and gunners Sgt. James A. Hinson and Sgt. Alfred H. Gerrans, Jr.

They were flying the 'hump', US Air Force's slang for the treacherous air corridor over the Himalayas which connected 13 bases in north-eastern India with six bases in China, when they vanished without a trace. Later that year, the B-24 was declared missing and the crew presumed dead.

Cut to December 7, 2006. Clayton Kuhles, 54, a doughty Indiana Jonesesque American adventurer with a unique passion for discovering crashed US aircraft—with seven credited discoveries in India—was purposefully trekking through Siang district in northern Arunachal Pradesh. His guide Oken Tayeng had told him of an old airplane wreckage in the mountains near Tayeng's ancestral village of Damrah. They hired a local Abor

hunter and porters and completed the gruelling three-day trek from the village. Kuhles reached the spot of the wreckage nearly 9,000 ft high up a ravine. There were aircraft parts and human bones scattered between trees and moss-covered rocks on the mountain slopes. There were, however, no numbers to identify the aircraft which had evidently run out of fuel before it crashed on the hillside because there was no fire. As he was readying to leave, Kuhles spotted a pile of aluminum panels placed on one side years earlier by a local hunter who had planned to salvage them and later sell as scrap. He flipped over a panel with the model number of B-24 and the number 42-73308 stencilled on it. It was the Hot as Hell.

Now the Hot as Hell and several crashed aircraft like her are to become the subject of a joint Indo-US military expedition to recover the remains of their Missing in Action (MIA) crewmen, giving a new hue to military ties between the two countries. Last week the Indo-US Defence Policy Group, the apex body for Indo-US defence and mil-

itary cooperation, decided to commence recovery operations of the remains of the missing US personnel.

The meeting, held in Washington DC between January 14 and 18 between Defence Secretary Vijay Singh and the US Under-Secretary for Defence Eric Edelman discussed several confirmed crash sites in north-eastern India and agreed to bring closure to several families.

"We are treating this as a humanitarian gesture and we have no objections to the US teams coming into the North-east," Defence Ministry officials told INDIA TODAY. The missions were cleared by the Ministry of Home Affairs which overruled reservations expressed by Intelligence Bureau: the North-east is still a sensitive area with restricted access to foreigners. This is one reason why recovery teams from the Joint Prisoners of War/MIA Accounting Command (JPAC) headquartered in Hawaii, will be accompanied by the Indian military.

The Indian Air Force (IAF) will provide the rescue and search facilities for JPAC and the teams will be escorted by